

Cards bounce Avon Vega moves into 2nd on Lorain County scoring list

Jim Jablonski
The Chronicle-Telegram

SHEFFIELD — After a series of tough losses throughout the season, the Brookside Cardinals had something to prove in their final regular season game.

This time they made believers of themselves, their fans and most of all the Avon Eagles with a wild 77-73 Lorain County Conference victory.

"We have been talking about Brookside Pride all week," said coach Gene Leonard. "The players deserved this one. They haven't folded all year and this time it paid off."

The game ended with senior Robby Jackman flat on his back after hitting a clinching free throw with four seconds left. He had missed the first of the two-shot opportunity.

"It was over, all we had to do was keep from fouling," Jackman explained. "I was shocked when I missed the first but my father gave me a thumbs-up sign before the second and I had to make it."

The win avenged an earlier 97-67 loss at Avon back on January 27. It also raised the Cardinals' record to 5-15 overall, 2-12 in the LCC. The Eagles, who have lost four of their last five, finished the regular season at 11-9 and 7-7.

The game featured Brookside's scoring balance against the 44-point effort of Avon's Steve Vega. That total raised Vega's career scoring to 1940 points, good for second place on the all-time Lorain County scoring list. He moved ahead of Columbia's Dan Hagen who finished with 1903 in 1972. Bill Szabo, who played for Firelands from 1977 to 1980, is far beyond with 2567.

Those numbers meant little to the happy Cardinals. Jackman led Brookside with 20 while Glenn Smith followed with 15. Jason Blaseg added 11 and Tom Nagy and Dave Adkins each added 10.

The Cardinals broke out quickly with a 25-11 first-quarter lead but the Eagles worked their way back through the middle periods. Their 61-52 lead with seven minutes to play seemed to promise a big victory.

But Blaseg followed with a pair of quick layups off offensive rebounds and the Cardinals were on the way back. Nagy, Smith and Jackman each hit threes and Brookside caught the visitors at 70.

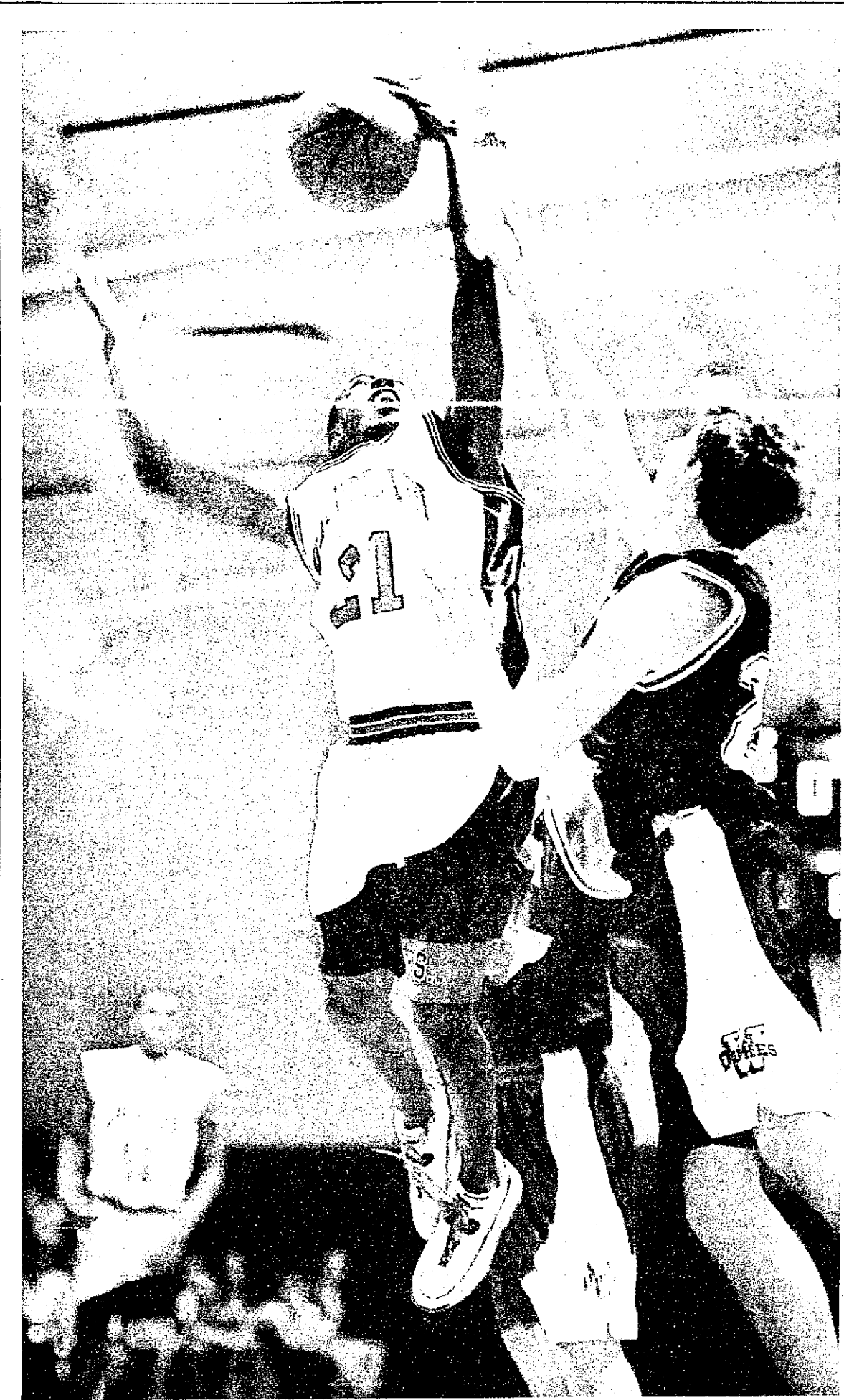
"Tommy Nagy got me the ball. I looked at the rim and saw an arc right to the basket. I just followed it," said an ecstatic Jackman. "But everyone came through tonight, the seniors, the juniors, everyone."

Avon varsity assistant Mike Kelly filled in for head coach Dave Kudela who was ill. "We didn't start well but made a great effort in the middle quarters," Kelly said. "They (the Cardinals) hit some big shots at the end and we needed to take care of the ball better."

Brookside					Avon				
G	F	T	G	F	T	G	F	T	
Jackman	5	4	22	Vega	13	11	44		
Nagy	2	4	19	O'Reilly	2	0	4		
Smith	2	6	0	Ball	1	0	3		
Blaseg	4	3	11	Wimmer	1	3	1	7	
Adkins	3	0	10	Krelowski	0	0	0		
Frost	2	1	8	Brunner	0	0	0		
Leonard	3	0	7	Butenko	0	0	0		
Kvasnok	0	0	0	Corbett	2	2	6		
Totals	27	13	77	Totals	25	15	73		
Points by Quarters					Points by Quarters				
1 2 3 4 T					1 2 3 4 T				
Brookside					Avon				
25 14 13 25 — 77					11 25 21 — 73				
Three-point goals: Brookside — Jackman, 4; Smith, 3; Nagy, 2; Leonard, 1; Frost, 1; Blaseg, 1; Adkins, 1; Kvasnok, 0.					Avon — Vega, 7; Ball, 1; Wimmer, 1; Brunner, 0; Butenko, 0; Corbett, 2.				
Junior Varsity: Brookside, 51-34.									

NORTH RIDGEVILLE — Midpark used a 13-5 run in the final two minutes of the game to turn back upset-minded North Ridgeville, 74-66, in the Pioneer Conference finale for both teams Friday night.

With the score tied at 61, Midpark's David Pisarcik stole the ball and passed to Jonathan Carroll, who hit a 3-point shot. Carroll then followed with a basket and a free throw and the Meteors lead was 67-61. Midpark then closed out the game at the free throw line going 7 for 8 as the Rangers were forced to foul to get the ball back.



LINDA MURPHY / CHRONICLE

GETTING UP: Oberlin's point guard Jeff Chambers goes high for an underhanded layup over Wellington's Christian Stevens. Chambers scored 23 to lead both teams in scoring.

Sizzling second-half story Hot final half carries Oberlin past Wellington

Jerry Rombach
The Chronicle-Telegram

OBERLIN — Out of the running for a Lorain County Conference boys basketball championship, Oberlin and Wellington both looked at Friday's regular-season finale in terms of keeping positive momentum going into the postseason.

Oberlin was by far the most impressive in the tourney tuneup with an 84-63 romp over the Ducks.

Both teams had won three straight going into the game. Oberlin has now taken four in a row and five of the last six. The Indians will carry an 11-9 record into their Division III tourney debut Tuesday at Elyria High against Clearview.

The Clippers were one of Oberlin's victims in the recent hot streak.

Wellington fell to 13-7 overall going into next Wednesday's Division III opener against Black River.

In the last half Friday night the Indians looked like they were the LCC champs, shooting a sizzling 58 percent the final two quarters, hitting 11 of 16 in the fourth. For the game, they connected on 52 percent of their shots.

Oberlin					Well.				
G	F	T	G	F	T	G	F	T	
Chambers	5	8	23	Pycroft	5	5	0	13	
Gibbs	5	0	22	Mills	3	3	11		
White	5	1	14	Cn.Stevens	5	0	10		
Daniels	2	0	12	Goss	3	3	9		
Barnes	2	0	7	Ogle	4	0	9		
Whithead	0	2	2	Sword	4	1	9		
McKinney	0	2	2	Cr.Stevens	0	2	2		
Davis	1	0	2	Sherry	0	0	0		
Pick	0	0	0	Baker	0	0	0		
Tarrant	0	0	0	Whitney	0	0	0		
Totals	31	14	84	Totals	25	5	63		
Points by Quarters					Points by Quarters				
1 2 3 4 T					1 2 3 4 T				
Oberlin					Wellington				
16 18 20 30 — 84					17 15 13 18 — 63				
Three-point goals: Oberlin: Andrew Gibbs, 4; Scottie White, 3; Jeff Chambers, Wellington: Troy Mills, 2; Kyle Pycroft, Jeremy Ogle.					Junior Varsity: Wellington 45-38.				

"We should have been conference champs if we hadn't lost those two at the buzzer to Avon and Keystone," Oberlin coach Joe Harris said.

"We've been shooting well," he added. "I'm pleased because the kids are playing with intensity and they've got their minds on the game."

Will Oberlin carry the momentum to Elyria High next week?

"I sure hope so," Harris said. Oberlin scored 171 points in games Tuesday and Friday, giving up just 128.

A big reason was demonstrated Friday night when Oberlin's half-court trapping defense kept the Ducks off balance most of the game. The constant pressure on the ball handler out front played a role in holding Wellington's star Troy Mills to his lowest point total of the season, 11.

But, despite being outscored 50-31 the last half, Wellington was still relative close with 7:40 remaining in the fourth quarter. The Ducks trailed by only six, 54-48.

Then Oberlin exploded.

Time after time the Indians either stole the ball and drove for a layup or drilled a 3-pointer. They had eight treys for the game, along with five fast-break baskets.

"In a game like this, what can you say?" Wellington coach Jerry Camp said. "They just got on fire in the second half and there wasn't anything you can do to stop it. We kept throwing everything at them and they just kept throwing it (the ball) in."

While Oberlin shot 52 percent, Wellington was at 40. The Ducks had 19 turnovers, Oberlin 15. Wellington, mostly because of a 15-6 edge in the third quarter, won the rebound battle 40-32.

Both teams finished 8-6 in the conference, tied for fourth place behind co-champs Midview and Keystone and third-place Clearview.

Two share SWC crown

Olmsted Falls is on top again

Bob Daniels
The Chronicle-Telegram

WESTLAKE — Olmsted Falls earned a share of its third straight Southwestern Conference basketball championship Friday night creating the kind of game it likes best — a sloppy one.

The young Bulldogs jumped on Westlake, 78-59, to tie Rocky River for the title. It was the 41st victory in their last 42 SWC games over three seasons. Their only loss in that span was at home to Rocky River, 56-44, on Jan. 31 this year.

River assured its share of the title with an 80-47 thumping of North Olmsted Friday night.

"One of the things we want to do is make the game sloppy," said Falls coach Pat Donahue. "We don't want to play sloppy. We want to make the other guys play sloppy."

"We're not a pretty team with our pressing style and the idea is to get the other team to turn the ball over. Then if we get enough layups, we beat you."

Falls was eminently successful on that score.

The Bulldogs forced 29 Westlake turnovers with a pressing, diving defense that got the ball back for them 20 times in the middle two quarters alone.

They scored 15 field goals during the stretch and, in keeping with Donahue's plan, made 11 of them either on layups or on shots inside the paint.

"The sloppier it gets, the better off we are," Donahue said. "It benefits us a lot more than it helps the other team. We practice at a very fast pace. We want to get it going up and down that way."

Falls led by only seven, 35-28, at halftime, but came out — to paraphrase Donahue — at a very fast pace after the break.

The Bulldogs went on a 19-2 tear, with Manzie Williams scoring eight of his game-high 18 points along the way. Their

O'Falls					Westlake				
G	F	T	G	F	T	G	F	T	
Mucha	2	5	9	Diamond	1	2	4		
Knapp	2	4	9	Jones	1	0	5		
Koch	1	0	2	Giulano	1	0	2		
MWilliams	8	0	18	Noel	2	2	9		
Szzech	4	2	10	Poll	2	2	6		
Gansay	6	0	12	Fiebig	3	1	7		
BWilliams	0	1	1	Inch	4	2	10		
Chapman	2	5	14	Mechum	3	0	8		
Church	0	0	0	Fischer	1	4	6		
Holland	0	1	1	Verdova	0	0	0		
Miller	1	0	2	Hrbng	1	2	4		
Totals	28	19	78	Totals	20	15	59		
Points by Quarters					Points by Quarters				
1 2 3 4 T					1 2 3 4 T				
O'Falls					Westlake				
18 17 24 19 — 78					9 19 9 22 — 59				
Three-point goals: Olmsted Falls — M. Williams, 2; Knapp, Westlake — Jones.					Junior varsity: Olmsted Falls, 51-41.				

pressing, gambling defense produced nine Westlake turnovers during the stretch and held the Demons without a field goal for six minutes and 14 seconds.

Olmsted Falls finished its regular season schedule 16-4, 13-1 in the conference. Westlake bowed out in front of a seniors' night crowd at 9-11, 7-7 SWC.

"The first two championships were special because we won them outright," Donahue said. "But this one's special in its own way because nobody gave us a snowball's chance in you-know-where. There were even some people at our own school who didn't believe we'd be here. But here we are. It's a real tribute to these kids."

The Olmsted Falls girls, incidentally, also tied for the SWC championship.

The Bulldog boys start only one senior, along with two sophomores and two juniors and with a freshman as sixth man. In short, they will bring a lot back next season.

In support of the 6-foot Manzie Williams, one of the juniors, 6-2 Sean Radigan, scored 14 points, and the freshman, 6-3 Mike Gansay, came off the bench to add 12.

Tom Inch, a 6-3 senior, led Westlake scorers with 10 points and was the only Demon in double figures. Senior Brian Pell scored nine.

River wins 1st title in five years

Bob West
The Chronicle-Telegram

ROCKY RIVER — The newspapers on Rocky River coach Jim Rucki's desk after his squad's 109-58 victory to open the Southwestern Conference season back in December carried headlines about the Pirates challenging Olmsted Falls two-year stronghold on SWC supremacy.

At the time, Rucki admitted his team had such potential but claimed his team had a lot of areas to improve upon if it was to challenge the Bulldogs. In that case, the work must be complete.

Friday night's 80-47 blistering of the visiting North Olmsted Eagles earned the Pirates a (18-2, 13-1) share of the SWC championship with Olmsted Falls. The title is the Pirates' first since the 1992-93 season, and it was delivered courtesy of a shooting performance Rucki has long been waiting for.

Behind the red-hot hand of Jeff Peate, the Pirates turned an 18-16 deficit after the first quarter into a 43-28 lead at halftime. Rocky River started the quarter by connecting on its first eight field goal attempts, including seven consecutive 3-point baskets from five different players.

Peate connected for 10 points in the quarter, en route to 17-point first half.

The Eagles made a run at the Pirates to start the second half and got within 10 at 50-40 after Mike Husak's fifth of six 3-pointers on the night. But Rocky River answered by scoring the next eight points in a two-minute span that included two Eagle turnovers and two Pirate steals.

One more Pirate basket from beyond the arc, this one from Bob Clutterbuck with a second left in the third quarter, made it a 61-42 Pirate lead and buried the Eagles.

"I've been dreaming of those guys shooting like that for three or four years," Rucki said afterward. "We've got five guys who can shoot the ball consistently, but it seems like we haven't had

N. Olm.					R. River				
G	F	T	G	F	T	G	F	T	
Janis	1	0	2	Peate	6	4	20		
Steele	3	1	7	Dolan	4	0	10		
Hazzard	2	0	4	Richard	0	2	2		
Meczka	3	0	6	Clutterbuck	4	0	10		
Husak	6	0	22	Kennedy	6	0	13		
Sung	1	0	2	Bulpsot	2	0	3		
Wingenfeld	2	0	4	Holmes	1	1	3		
				Woodward	5	4	15		
				Miller	1	0	2		
Totals	20	1	47	Totals	29	11	80		
Points by Quarters					Points by Quarters				
1 2 3 4 T					1 2 3 4 T				
N. Olmsted					Rocky River				
18 10 14 5 — 47					16 27 18 19 — 80				
Three-point goals: North Olmsted — Husak, 6; Rocky River — Peate, 4; Dolan, 2; Clutterbuck, 2; Woodward, Kennedy, Holmes.					Junior Varsity — North Olmsted 52-40.				

more than two shooting well for any one game."

Rucki said his team's recent run though the second half of the SWC schedule has prepared it for the tournament. "After the first half of the conference schedule, we were one game down to Olmsted Falls, so we really had to play seven must win games in a row," Rucki said. "The tournament shouldn't be any different. In fact, I think the pressure is off us now, and we can just go out and play."

North Olmsted coach Tim Schmotzer was left searching for another opponent that shot so well against his team. "I don't remember ever giving up seven, threes in a row," he said. "But give Rocky River credit. They've had a lot of adversity this year, and coach Rucki did a great job keeping them together."

Peate led the Pirates with 20 points, but the entire starting lineup of Mike Woodward (15 points), Sean Kennedy (13 points), Clutterbuck (10 points) and Connell Dolan (10 points) scored in double figures. Husak led all scorers with 22 points.

The Pirates, the No. 1 seed in the Lorain Admiral King sectional tournament, have a first round bye and open tournament play March 7 against the winner of the Brookside/Revere contest. North Olmsted (11-9, 8-6) battles Midview on Monday as part of the Cloverleaf sectional.

HIGH SCHOOL NOTEBOOK

BOTH OBERLIN and Wellington open Division III boys sectional tourney play next week against teams that had beaten them in the regular season. Oberlin faces Clearview on Tuesday at Elyria High. The Indians lost to the Clippers 67-80 early in the season, but did even the season's series with a 64-61 win later. Wellington meets Black River Wednesday, also at Elyria. The Pirates downed the Ducks 56-45 early in the season.

GENE LEONARD, Brookside head coach, revealed how his team was able to defeat the Avon Eagles Friday night despite Steve Vega's 44 points. "The first time we played them we double-teamed him and he still scored over 40," Leonard said of his Cardinals 97-67 loss in late January. "This time we played just a straight up man defense all game. He got his 44 but no one else scored in double figures. And we had five who did."